The Mallah community, Santosh tells me, is also split in its political loyalties, mostly between the BJP and the Samajwadi Party. He hates the ruling party for its corporation-friendly market ethos that brought in the cruise ship, but his deeper animus springs from its championing of the Kashi Vishwanath corridor, an urban development project. Vishwanath Temple is the city's most revered shrine to Shiva, located in the old town. The project will create wide roads, parking and a modern tourist zone around the temple, leading down to the river. The project has already razed many neighbourhoods, including lots of Hindu temples and shrines (Santosh claims 350) tucked into the old town's cramped streets and courtyards.[42] Santosh, a pious Hindu, considers this sacrilege. 'God is watching,' he says. 'Any Hindu who destroys temples so callously cannot be called Hindu. Further, what kind of Hindu polarizes Hindus and Muslims to win Hindu votes? That's the one thing this party does best. They're now even targeting the Gyanvapi Mosque.'[43]

Back in my room, I continue reading Diana Eck's *Banaras: City of Light*. I've come to admire it for its wealth of information, but I've also had some trouble with it. It now strikes me that perhaps this is because Eck wallows too much in Hindu mythologies, often romanticizing their philosophical import while overlooking the lived realities of Hinduism. She fails to subject Hindu beliefs and practices to even modest rational criticism and betrays a superficial grasp of caste and its pathologies, a common weakness in both non-Indian and upper-caste accounts of Indian society. Her narrative illustrates to me why history needs to be continually rewritten.

The City of Death and Moksha

Death may be the world's greatest leveller, but no 'city on earth is as famous for death as is Banaras', writes Eck. 'More than for her temples and magnificent ghats, more than for her silks and brocades, Banaras, the Great Cremation Ground, is known for death.' And no place in Varanasi brings this home as much as its two main cremation ghats: Manikarnika and Harishchandra.

In Hindu lore, anyone who dies and is cremated in Varanasi gains instant moksha. Normally, moksha is gained either by a demanding journey of self-